MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 3 — Unit 2: Shylock Is My Name - Howard Jacobson

SHAKESPEARE STUDIES • M21EG02DC

Expanded exam notes | Simple teaching + developed argument

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material. Use the assigned primary texts for exact quotations and full scene or passage analysis.

The chapter in one sentence

Howard Jacobson reworks The Merchant of Venice to investigate Jewish identity, inherited prejudice, family authority, revenge, and the difficulty of mercy.

Start with a picture

Imagine a much-discussed character entering a modern conversation about the way he has been described for centuries. He does not simply accept the old judgement. The conversation makes both the original story and the present world look different.

1. Title, author, and project

The novel is Shylock Is My Name, published in 2016 as part of the Hogarth Shakespeare project. The course's later use of "My Name is Shylock" is a title inconsistency; use the published title in your answers.

The source play is The Merchant of Venice. Knowing its bond, trial, Jessica plot, and contested language of mercy helps explain what the reworking changes.

2. The new setting and principal figures

Contemporary Cheshire replaces the original play's Venetian world. Simon Strulovitch, a wealthy Jewish art collector, encounters Shylock. The novel brings the Shakespearean character into a modern setting rather than pretending simply to supply a realistic historical sequel.

Strulovitch's daughter Beatrice seeks independence and is involved with the footballer Gratan Howsome, whose antisemitic behaviour intensifies the conflict. D'Anton and Plurabelle belong to the surrounding social world. The relationship between Strulovitch and Shylock provides an important intellectual centre.

3. The family parallel

Shylock's memories of Jessica's departure intersect with Strulovitch's fear of losing Beatrice. A daughter's choice becomes entangled with a father's fear about cultural continuity and exclusion.

Do not assume that a father’s experience of prejudice proves that every restriction he imposes is justified. Equally, do not treat the historical weight of prejudice as an excuse to dismiss his fear. The tension is the point.

4. The bond transformed

The demand for a pound of flesh is reworked through a demand involving circumcision. This change links bodily power, belonging, masculinity, and religious identity. It should be analysed as a fictional device, not treated as a description of ordinary Jewish life or as a sensational joke.

The episode asks whether revenge can repair humiliation or simply reproduce coercion. The question of mercy becomes inseparable from who controls the terms on which it is offered.

5. Conversation, comedy, and postmodern form

Shylock’s presence blurs boundaries between Shakespeare’s fiction and Jacobson’s present. Characters discuss identity and arguments about their source. Such self-awareness creates an **intertextual** relationship: one work speaks through and against another.

The novel’s dark comedy can expose prejudice, complacency, and the instability of supposedly generous positions. It does not require readers to accept either central man as a flawless moral spokesman.

6. Important themes

Assimilation means becoming absorbed into a dominant culture, sometimes with pressure to minimise a distinct identity. **Antisemitism** is hostility or discrimination directed at Jews. **Historical memory** connects present reactions with inherited experiences of exclusion.

No one fictional character represents an entire community. Attend to differences among figures and to the narrator’s methods.

Quick check

1. Is this simply the original play in modern clothes? **No; it changes the questions and the distribution of voices.**
2. Why does the daughter plot matter? **It connects personal authority with identity and belonging.**
3. Should every claim by Shylock be treated as Jacobson’s final position? **No.**

Build an exam answer

1. Identify the novel, source, and modern setting.
2. Explain Strulovitch’s encounter with Shylock.
3. Develop the daughter parallel and its tensions.
4. Analyse the transformed bond and conditions of mercy.
5. Connect identity questions with dialogue and intertextual form.

Common mistake to avoid

Use Shylock Is My Name, not the reversed title. Do not generalise from fictional behaviour to a religious community or assume all the textbook's compressed character descriptions are consistent.

Developed exam discussion

Practice question

How does Jacobson's adaptation reopen questions of identity and mercy?

Explain the argument in fuller paragraphs

Shylock Is My Name makes adaptation an act of argument with an inherited representation. By placing Shylock alongside Simon Strulovitch in contemporary England, Jacobson brings historical judgement into contact with present-day anxieties. The older character's presence prevents the original play from remaining a closed cultural object. Readers are asked to reconsider what has been assumed about Jewish difference, anger, and the availability of mercy.

The parallel daughter relationships give these questions emotional force. Jessica's departure and Beatrice's search for independence are not identical events, but the relation between them allows paternal fear to cross historical settings. That fear includes both affection and a desire for control. A critical answer should recognise the injury produced by prejudice while also examining what fathers demand from daughters in the name of cultural survival.

The transformed bond makes bodily vulnerability and identity central. Its coercive logic raises the question of whether retaliation can undo an earlier humiliation. Mercy offered from a secure position can itself preserve inequality if the giver controls the conditions of acceptance. The adaptation therefore does more than reverse sympathy between familiar sides; it investigates the power built into the language of generosity.

The novel's dialogue and self-conscious encounter with Shakespeare create a specifically literary form for this investigation. A strong answer connects themes with narrative method, showing how conversation, dark comedy, and intertextual recognition let the past disturb the present. It should not claim that the work gives a single uncomplicated verdict on either Jewishness or the source play.

How to use this discussion

Adapt the argument to the exact wording and marks of your question. Use one point per paragraph and support it with a scene, line, image, or formal detail. Verify exact quotations in the assigned text. The discussion is explanatory paraphrase, not a quotation or a guaranteed model answer.

Textbook assignment checklist

These are the unit's assignment prompts for revision. They are not predictions or a set of fully written assignment submissions.

1. Discuss how Howard Jacobson reimagines Shylock and what new perspectives he brings to the character.

2. Explore the theme of father-daughter conflict in the novel and how it relates to cultural identity and assimilation.
3. Imagine you are Beatrice. Write a letter explaining your feelings about your father’s demands and your place in society.
4. Investigate the Hogarth Shakespeare project and the idea of reinterpreting classic plays for modern readers.